

Email platform decision: Klaviyo, Spoks or an alternative

For discussion between Layton and his business partner · 28 September 2026 · prepared with Claude from hands-on tests of Klaviyo and Spoks, plus web research on alternatives

1. The decision

We have a complete build pack for a new email and SMS flow programme — 14 flows covering welcome, membership, abandonment, post-purchase, winback and sunset. It was written for Klaviyo. We are testing whether to build it somewhere cheaper, using Claude connected to each platform to do most of the work.

The question: stay on Klaviyo, move to Spoks, or trial another platform first?

2. At a glance

	Klaviyo	Spoks
Monthly cost	About \$720/month list price at ~46k active profiles (≈£535 + VAT), SMS extra. <i>Confirm against our actual bill.</i>	\$35/month, no send cap. SMS extra, on credits.
Email design quality	High. Claude can write fully designed, branded HTML emails.	Basic. Claude can only place plain blocks; colours, backgrounds and card styling are set by hand.
Reusable blocks (tier table, USP bar, banners)	Claude creates and updates them. They need Klaviyo’s “hybrid” template format, not pure code.	Built by hand in a pop-up. Claude cannot see or insert them.
Building the flows	By hand in Klaviyo. The build pack gives click-by-click steps.	Automatic. Claude creates every flow, step, delay and filter — all inactive until we switch them on.
Fit with our build pack	Native — it was written for Klaviyo.	Needs translating, with gaps (section 4).
Account readiness	Ready: 46k list, SMS live, reporting history.	Not ready: 6,059 subscribed contacts (vs 46,334 in Klaviyo — unexplained), SMS off, sender email not set, paid plan needed.
Our manual effort	Wiring ~14 flows by hand, then attaching Claude’s designs.	Building ~3–4 text blocks by hand, styling each email layout once, placing blocks into ~40 emails.

3. Klaviyo

Pros

- Best-looking emails for the least effort: Claude writes the designs and reusable blocks.
- Everything in the build pack works as written: splits, smart sending, bounce filters, A/B subject tests, emails sent “from Alex”.
- No migration risk: list, consent, SMS and history already in place.
- The existing flows can be edited in place.

Cons

- Flow wiring is manual: ~14 flows in the Klaviyo UI.
- Cost: ~\$720/month, around 20× Spoks. Suppressing unengaged profiles lowers it.
- Klaviyo’s raw API can now create flows (beta) but not edit them or add A/B tests; the connector Claude uses can’t, so flows stay manual in practice.

4. Spoks

Pros

- Much cheaper: \$35/month, no send cap.
- Claude builds all the flows: triggers, delays, “next day at 09:30” timing, audience filters.
- Membership tier tags already sync from Shopify, so membership flows can trigger directly.
- Abandonment emails show the customer’s real basket with a link back.
- Brand colours and fonts are already applied.

Cons

- Limited design: no HTML/code and no design import.
- Reusable blocks built and placed by hand.
- Gaps: no per-email “from Alex” sender; no bounce filter; no A/B subject tests via Claude; tag-triggered flows enrol a customer only once; category paths become separate flows.
- Go-live work: paid plan, sender and domain, SMS set-up, explain the 6k vs 46k contact gap.

5. Tests we ran that didn’t work

- **Spoks components via Claude:** not possible — Spoks components can only be built by hand.
- **Designing visuals in Canva for Spoks:** quality wasn’t good enough; dropped.

6. Other platforms researched

Each checked against the same test: can Claude build the flows, can Claude build designed emails, and how well does it know Shopify. Figures come from web search results, not the vendors’ own pricing pages — treat prices as indicative and confirm before signing up.

Platform	Claude builds flows?	Claude builds designed emails?	Shopify depth	Approx. cost at our size
Spoks	Yes (tested)	No — basic blocks only (tested)	Good	\$35/month
Klaviyo	No via connector; beta API only	Yes (tools confirmed, not yet trialled)	Best	~\$720/month
Omnisend	Possibly — its official connector claims it can; unconfirmed	Yes — HTML import and reusable “Universal Layouts”	Good (Shopify-first); “delivered” and back-in-stock need extras	Not found — needs a quote
Brevo	No — built by hand	Yes — HTML templates; synced reusable sections	Moderate, via the PushOwl app	~\$100–130/month
MailerLite	Probably — guided automation builder	Yes	Weak	~\$160+/month

Platform	Claude builds flows?	Claude builds designed emails?	Shopify depth	Approx. cost at our size
Mailchimp, Drip, ActiveCampaign, Dotdigital	No	Mostly yes	Mixed	\$450–970/month or quote
Shopify Messaging + Flow	Only Shopify's own in-app AI	No	Native	Very cheap

What this means

- **No platform we could confirm lets Claude build both the flows and the designs.** Everyone else splits the work like Klaviyo or Spoks.
- **Omnisend is the one to check.** If its connector really builds automations, it could automate both halves with good Shopify coverage at a mid price. Needs a free-trial test first.
- **Brevo is a cheaper Klaviyo.** Claude builds the designs; we wire the flows. Thinner Shopify link, and its discount codes share one fixed expiry date rather than “7 days from sending”, which clashes with our coupon rules.
- **MailerLite** is cheap and AI-buildable, but too thin on Shopify for our membership tiers and category routing.
- Everything else costs more than Klaviyo for less, or can't be built by an AI at all.

7. What drives the choice

If this matters most...	...lean towards
Lowest running cost	Spoks, then Brevo
Best-looking emails, fastest	Klaviyo
Least risk / fastest to go live	Klaviyo (nothing to migrate)
Least manual setup of flows	Spoks (Omnisend if its test passes)
Automation of both flows and design	Omnisend — only if the trial confirms it
Following the build pack exactly	Klaviyo

Either way: the copy, rules and flow logic in the build pack stay the same. Prices, warranty terms, delivery times and other items marked [CONFIRM] still need checking before anything goes live, and nothing is activated without our sign-off.

8. Next steps

- Confirm our current Klaviyo monthly cost so the saving is a real number.
- Optional: a short Omnisend trial — connect it to Claude and test one abandonment flow with one designed email, draft only.
- Decide the platform.
- If Spoks: subscribe to the paid plan, set up the sender, and investigate the 6,059 vs 46,334 contact gap.
- If Klaviyo: Claude builds the designs and reusable blocks while we wire the flows.